

What else to watch: *Mean Streets* (1973) ■ *The Deer Hunter* (1978) ■ *Raging Bull* (1980, pp.338–39) ■ *The King of Comedy* (1982) ■ *After Hours* (1985)

he has lost his faith in the country that he was fighting for. Even his ability to sleep has deserted him. Most crucially, he has lost his way in life. "All my life needed was a sense of someplace to go," he murmurs in his half-awake, half-dreaming narration, as he glides endlessly through the night in his taxi, taking others to their destinations. Travis's eyes are glimpsed on-screen in the rear-view mirror, as though the audience

Travis determines to save Iris (Jodie Foster), a 12-year-old prostitute, from her pimp, Sport, whether she wants him to or not. By saving her, Travis can be the cleansing rain.

are his passengers—but, like him, they have no idea where they are heading.

Ride through hell

From the opening moments of *Taxi Driver*, Scorsese invites the viewer into the tormented mind of this antihero, suggesting his character's instability through chaotically arranged images and camera angles.

The first shot of the movie is a cloud of steam venting from the sewers, tinged by red neon light. It looks like brimstone rising from hell, and Travis's cab appears suddenly in its midst, as if it is »



Martin Scorsese

Director

"My whole life has been movies and religion," Martin Scorsese once said. "That's it. Nothing else." He was born a Catholic in Queens, New York, in 1942, and movies have become for him a religion in themselves, an art form to revere and treasure.

Scorsese studied film at New York University. He directed his first feature, *I Call First*, in 1967. Since then, his output has been diverse, from gritty urban thrillers to grand historical dramas, paying homage to screen classics.

Religion finds its way into most of his movies, most notably *The Last Temptation of Christ* (1988) and *Kundun* (1997). He also has another great passion: New York City, the subject of so much of his work, from his first major success, *Mean Streets*, to *Gangs of New York*.

Key movies

1973 *Mean Streets*
1976 *Taxi Driver*
1980 *Raging Bull*
1990 *Goodfellas*
2002 *Gangs of New York*
2006 *The Departed*